

Word family: **ceiling / ceilings**

Base word: ceiling

Plural: ceilings

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Inside, the **ceilings** are high, the space feels open...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **ceiling** means the **upper interior surface of a room or building**.

繁體中文： **天花板；房間或建築物內部最上方的表面**

中文翻譯：

> “Inside, the **ceilings** are high...”

「裡面的**天花板**很高.....」

Here:

high ceilings = 高樓底 / 高天花板

1. **ceiling = upper interior surface of a room (建築) — 天花板**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: The top inside surface of a room or enclosed space.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The **ceilings** are high.”

「**天花板**很高。」

Practice 2

> “The bedroom has a low **ceiling**.”

「睡房的**天花板**很低。」

Practice 3

> “A light was hanging from the **ceiling**.”

「一盞燈從**天花板**垂下來。」

ceiling = 房間或室內空間最上方的內部表面

Common:

* high ceiling

* low ceiling

* ceiling light

* ceiling fan

2. **ceiling** = upper limit / maximum allowed level (上限) — 上限；最高限度

Ceiling can also mean the highest amount, level, price, number, etc. that is allowed or possible.

Practice 4

> “The government introduced a price **ceiling**.”

「政府設立了價格**上限**。」

Practice 5

> “There is a strict spending **ceiling**.”

「支出有嚴格的**上限**。」

ceiling = 某個數值、價格、支出、收入等所能達到的最高限制

Common:

* price ceiling

* spending ceiling

* debt ceiling

* salary ceiling

This is a major figurative sense.

3. **ceiling** = highest possible level someone can reach (發展 / 晉升) — 上限 ; 瓶頸**

Ceiling can refer to a limit on advancement or achievement.

Practice 6

> “She felt she had reached a **ceiling** in her career.”

「她覺得自己的職業發展已經碰到**上限 / 瓶頸**。」

Practice 7

> “The role offers a higher earning **ceiling**.”

「這個職位有更高的收入**上限**。」

ceiling = 某人或某事所能發展、提升或達到的最高程度**

This is closely related to Meaning 2, but the focus is on **potential or advancement** rather than a formal rule.

For strict counting, I would usually merge this with #2.

4. **ceiling** = maximum altitude / upper boundary (航空 / 空間) — 升限 ; 上界**

In aviation and technical contexts, **ceiling** can mean the maximum altitude an aircraft can reach, or the height of the lowest cloud layer under certain conditions.

Practice 8

> “The aircraft has a service **ceiling** of 12,000 metres.”

「這架飛機的實用**升限**是 12,000 米。」

Practice 9

> “The cloud **ceiling** was very low.”

「雲底**高度 / 雲幕高度**很低。」

ceiling = 航空或氣象中可達到或可見的最高 / 最低界限高度**

This is an established specialist sense.

5. **ceiling** = barrier to advancement (固定比喻) — 無形上限

This appears in expressions such as:

> glass ceiling

Practice 10

> “Many women still face a **glass ceiling** in some industries.”

「很多女性在某些行業仍面對**玻璃天花板 / 無形晉升障礙**。」

glass ceiling = 阻礙某些群體晉升到更高職位的無形障礙

This is a lexicalized fixed expression built from the upper-limit sense.

Important distinction: **ceiling** vs **roof**

ceiling

= inside top surface of a room

roof

= outside top covering of a building

So:

> ceiling = 室內天花板

> roof = 建築物外部屋頂

This is one of the most important learner distinctions.

Important distinction: **ceiling** vs **top**

top

is very general.

ceiling

usually means either:

- * room's upper interior surface
- * maximum limit

So **top** is broader and less specific.

Important distinction: **ceiling vs limit**

limit

is the broad general word for a maximum or boundary.

ceiling

often emphasizes a hard upper boundary.

- > speed limit
- > spending ceiling

Not always interchangeable, but similar in many numerical contexts.

Important distinction: **ceiling vs cap**

cap

often means an imposed upper limit.

ceiling

can also mean a maximum limit, often in economics/finance or figuratively.

- > price cap
- > price ceiling

These overlap strongly.

Countability note

Ceiling is normally countable:

> a ceiling

> two ceilings

In the figurative sense:

> a salary ceiling

> several ceilings

also countable.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is very small:

* **ceiling**

* **ceilings**

Most modern uses cluster around two core concepts:

* **the upper inside surface**

* **an upper limit**

Technical aviation/weather uses and expressions like **glass ceiling** develop from the second concept.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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ceiling — room/building	房間或建築物內部最上方的表面；天花板
ceiling — upper limit	價格、支出、數值、能力等所能達到或被允許的最高限度
ceiling — career/potential	發展、收入或晉升所能達到的最高程度；通常併入 upper-limit 義
ceiling — aviation/weather	航空或氣象中的高度上限 / 雲幕高度
glass ceiling	阻礙某些群體晉升的無形障礙

For your original sentence

> “Inside, the **ceilings** are high...”

The exact meaning is:

ceilings = 建築物室內最上方的表面

So:

> **high ceilings**

= **高天花板 / 高樓底**

For your database, I would count **2 genuinely useful core meanings** for **ceiling**:

1. **the upper interior surface of a room**
2. **an upper limit or maximum level**

I would keep aviation/weather uses under #2 as specialist extensions, and treat **glass ceiling** as a fixed metaphor rather than inflate the base count.